THE INTERNATIONAL SYSTEM

The structure of the present day international system is quite complex and is increasingly becoming more complex. This is more so because of the changes in the nature of the component units of the system. Traditionally, it was only the states which were considered to be the vital parts of the international system or the primary actors, but now there has been an increasing recognition of the existence of other agents, or as they are now called *non-state actors* in international relations. Therefore, international system can be thought of as one combining several kinds of actors of varying degrees of autonomy in their international behaviour, with the states among them retaining a leading but by no means an exclusive role.[1]

By international system, some scholars mean a more complex concept involving a set of states and other actors interacting with each other. Any system is defined by the combination of the attributes of its component units and the nature, pattern, and number of interactions among those units. If this idea is applied to the international system, then the factors, which become important are:

- The number of state actors
- The relative size of various actors
- The number and types of non-state actors
- Linkages or interactions among state actors
- Interdependence among the units of the system.[2]

However, as Frankel points out, international system lacks two pre-requisites of domestic political systems, namely, the social basis of a community and the political structure of a government. International system does not possess any unconditional agreement on cooperation, on the precedence of some basic common good over sub-group or individual interests. It is built only on some limited and conditional cooperation, which sometimes degenerates into anarchy. In the absence of a hierarchically arranged government, there is no authority to determine the jurisdiction of all the social sub-groups and enforce norms and laws. What exists is only a loose structure and